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ORIGINAL PAPER

(En)Countering language ideologies: language policing in the ideospace of Facebook

Prem Phyak

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Abstract This paper takes language policing as an ideospace, a space where multiple language ideologies are constructed and contested. Drawing on critical language policy and linguistic anthropology, it unravels how participants in a Nepalese Facebook group construct and reproduce language ideologies that both challenge and impose homogeneity and uniformity. The study shows that Facebook language policing does not always embrace superdiverse conditions such as linguistic heterogeneity and fluidity, but reproduces language ideologies that consistently impose homogeneity. The analysis further shows that monolingual ideologies are reproduced through the iconization of Nepali as the national language and English as the language of technology and the global linguistic marketplace. Such iconization further erases the discourses that support the revitalization and use of minority languages in Facebook and other spaces. The study implies that the ideological contestation in Facebook language policing reflects public debate about politics, ethnicity, and nationalism in the offline context of Nepal.

Keywords Language ideology · Facebook · Language policy · Superdiversity · Policing · Ideospace

Introduction

Language ideologies have received increasing attention in language policy in the late modern world (e.g., Pennycook 2013; Tollefson 2013). With the increased flows

P. Phyak (✉)
Department of Second Language Studies, University of Hawai'i at Manoa, Honolulu, HI, USA
e-mail: pphyak@hawaii.edu; pphyak@gmail.com

P. Phyak
Department of English Education, Central Department of Education, Tribhuvan University, Kathmandu, Nepal

of technology, people, and media, scholars are reorienting language policy studies towards analyzing ideologies embedded in the unprecedented fluidity and multiplicity of language practices (Alim et al. 2009; Appadurai 1996; Blommaert 2010). Vertovec (2007) conceptualizes the notion of *superdiversity* to characterize the contemporary globalized diversity in which multiple variables such as ethnicity, language, politics, and economy are intertwined in one space. Recent studies have shown that the evolution of the Internet has further contributed to the creation of a superdiverse virtual space where individuals can benefit from an affordance to transcend their linguistic, ethnic, and cultural boundaries (Androutsopoulos 2007; Busch 2006; Castells 2011). Scholars (Ivkovic and Lotherington 2009; Pietikäinen and Piirainen-Marsh 2009) reveal that such border-crossings through the Internet result in complex multilingualism and heterogeneous language practices.

However, the superdiverse space of the Internet may also be constrained by certain norms and ideologies that limit individuals from using the multilingual resources at their disposal (Blommaert 2009; Varis and Wang 2011). Such norms and ideologies are created not only by nation-states, but also by individuals who participate in virtual interactions. In other words, the nation-state is only one language policy actor; other actors at the individual and non-state levels can also make their own language policies (Johnson 2013). Building on Foucault's (2007) *police*, Blommaert et al. (2009) characterize this kind of polycentric view as language *policing,* which is "the production of 'order'—normatively organized and policed conduct—which is infinitely detailed and regulated by a variety of actors" (p. 203). Foucault (2007) defines 'police' as the "the set of means by which the state's forces can be increased while preserving the state in good order" (p. 313). Language policing, in this sense, is not a disembodied text, but an actor-based discursive process in which multiple actors are engaged in constructing different ideologies that represent their voices and interests (Davis 2014; McCarty et al. 2011; Pennycook 2006). Such ideologies are multiple, contested, and shaped by larger sociopolitical conditions.

Recent studies have focused on how language policing in social media represents contested language ideologies (Blommaert 2009; Spotti 2011). Blommaert et al.'s (2009) conceptualization of the 'modernist response to postmodern conditions' is particularly important to understand the contested social mediaspace where both diversity and uniformity can co-exist. They argue that, although plurality and hybridization are visible, the "(re-)emergence of language ideologies stressing uniformity, stability, homogeneity" is equally salient in language policing in social media (p. 204). Social mediaspace not only constitutes the superdiversity of language, culture, and identity, but also reproduces the modernist ideologies that may impose *superuniformity* in language use and identity construction. Drawing on data from a Facebook group, this paper analyzes the contested language ideologies enacted in Facebook language policing and discusses what sociopolitical meanings these ideologies carry in the current sociopolitical context of a developing Asian country, Nepal. I build on heteroglossia (Bakhtin 1981) and the ideology of linguistic differentiation (Irvine and Gal 2000) to analyze the competing language ideologies that simultaneously construct and deconstruct linguistic homogeneity,

standardization, and hierarchies in Facebook language policing. In what follows, I discuss how language ideologies are constructed in social media.

Social media, language ideologies and heteroglossia

Recent studies have focused on increasing linguistic heterogeneity in the virtual space of social media. Blommaert et al. (2009) argue that language policing on the Internet often challenges the dominant language norms and provide a greater space for dynamic and fluid language practices. Androutsopoulos (2009) claims that social mediaspace is characterized by heterogeneous linguistic practices that

> […]drive home a key implication of *decentering*. When media are used to reinforce dominant ideologies of language in society just as well as to *challenge and subvert* them, there is nothing unified we can say about ''the media'' in terms of language policing. Rather, the very diversity of policing practices in today's heterogeneous media arenas is the point of departure. (p. 286, emphasis added)

This means that the social mediaspace is a contested space where dominant language ideologies are both reinforced and subverted. As Blommaert et al. (2009) argue, such ideological contestations provide a new perspective to understanding how heterogeneous language practices embrace multiple ideologies that challenge the modernist worldview of language policy as a unitary, fixed, and nation-state-governed phenomenon. In her recent study, Lenihan (2014) shows that translation apps on Facebook serve as a language policy mechanism for the Irish language community. Her study reveals that Facebook group members, depending on the context, engage in both top-down and bottom-up language policing, thereby challenging the fixed dichotomy between top-down and bottom-up policy (Shohamy 2006). Lenihan (2014) further argues that Facebook can provide community members with a democratic space to participate in language policing that addresses their interests and voices. While interpreting Facebook language policing as a fluid, ongoing and discursive process, she also claims that language ideologies play an important role in determining the choice of language used in Facebook.

Although studies have shown that social media and the Internet have deconstructed the top-down and bottom-up dichotomy and recognized hybrid and fluid language practices, we cannot deny that they can also be a mechanism to strengthen and reinforce homogeneity. Blommaert (2009) shows that online English language teaching programs, run by US-based private institutes, systematically impose American English on international students. Similarly, Leppänen and Peuronen (2012) argue that Internet sites implicitly develop certain types of 'regulatory mechanisms' that affect the choice and use of languages (p. 397). Facebook language policing in this sense requires critical scrutiny to have a better understanding of whether or not social media truly embrace heterogeneous language practices. We should take social media as a complex social space in which both superdiverse and superuniform language ideologies exist in contested power relations which are shaped by larger off-line sociopolitical and sociocultural

conditions. This implies that, as Blommaert and Rampton (2011) argue, our focus should be not only on language mixing and fluidity, but also on 'political and historical embedding' in language policing (p. 3). In other words, it is important to analyze how Facebook language policing reproduces multiple ideologies that represent the larger sociopolitical dynamics of a particular context.

Language ideologies constitute a wide range of issues concerning sociopolitical meanings of language. Woolard and Schieffelin (1994) maintain that language ideologies "are not only about language. Rather, [they]…envision and enact links of language to group and personal identity, to aesthetics, to morality, and to epistemology" (pp. 55–56). More specifically, language ideologies include an array of commonsense ideas, attitudes, and beliefs about language, interests of individuals and groups and social inequalities emanating from linguistic hierarchies (Gal 2005; Weber and Horner 2012). Irvine and Gal's (2000) three semiotic processes—*iconization, fractal recursivity* and *erasure*—provide a framework to analyze how language ideologies are constructed and reproduced in Facebook language policing. While iconization refers to the 'social image' and 'indexical meaning' of language, fractal recursivity is the "repetition of the same contrast but at different scales" (Gal 2005, p. 27). For example, the iconic comparison of indigenous and minority languages as savage and inappropriate in dominant society is closely linked with low sociopolitical power of indigenous and minority people around the globe (Cantoni 2007; Smith 2012). This kind of iconization is visible in the current global discourses in which English is given symbolic power in the global economy and education. Such iconization recurs at various times and spaces, such as in schools, families, and social media. Both iconization and fractal recursivity result in *erasure*, which Irvine and Gal (2000) define as a process that "renders some persons or activities or sociolinguistic phenomena invisible" (p. 38). As Irvine and Gal (2000) argue, erasure occurs when the "facts that are inconsistent with the ideological scheme either go unnoticed or get explained away" (p. 38). The delegitimization of multilingualism and heterogeneous language practices in education, government offices, and other public and private domains serves as an example of erasure of languages practices that do not fit into the dominant ideology—language as a fixed and bounded object.

Bakhtin's (1981) heteroglossia is a relevant analytical tool to unravel how language ideologies are constructed and contested in multilingual language practices. Focusing on social meanings, Bailey (2007) defines heteroglossia as the simultaneous use of different signs or forms in which contested sociohistorical associations are embedded. He argues that heteroglossia captures the indexical meanings or historicity of voices infused in multilingual practices. Bailey (2007) also claims that such meanings and voices are not explicit, rather they must be "interpreted on the basis of constellations of forms in particular interactional and sociohistorical contexts" (p. 258). Going beyond a linguacentric view, heteroglossia embraces the multiplicity of voices, discourses, and socio-ideological dimensions of language (Busch 2006). Blackledge et al. (2014) provide three key features of heteroglossia—indexicality, tension-filled interaction, and multivoicedness. While indexicality is concerned with the symbolic meaning of language which represents social class, identity, ethnicity, and nationality (Blommaert 2010), the tension-filled

interactions constitute contested language ideologies in language policing. Such ideological contestations result in multivoicedness; individuals enact multiple social positions—self and others—while evaluating and refuting ideologies (Bailey 2007). While indexical meaning and multivoicedness are equally important, the tension-filled interactions remain at the center of understanding the contested relationship between homogenizing ideologies and heterogeneous language practices.

As Bakhtin (1981) argues, the tension-filled interactions include two opposing forces—*centripetal* and *centrifugal*. While the centripetal forces include homogeneity, standardization, and purity, the centrifugal forces contain heteroglossic, non-standard, and fluid language practices. Critical language policy studies (e.g., Tollefson 2013; Wiley and Wright 2004) have argued that the standard language and purism ideologies discriminate against minority language speakers; these ideologies legitimize the upper-middle classes' language in public spheres while rejecting hybrid and vernacular language practices. Lippi-Green (1997) claims that by rejecting the lower class and minority peoples' language practices, the standard language ideology denies their identities and voices in the public sphere. Such ideologies are shaped by the assumption that nationality can only be fostered through monolingual policy (Anderson 1991). This assumption falsely iconizes multilingualism as a threat to nationalism.

Moore (2012) provides a compelling analysis of how the standard language ideology constrains the use of smaller (often indigenous and minority) languages in the current superdiverse world context. He claims that this ideology not only inhibits 'the free exchange of messages' and ignores 'obvious fact(s) of multilingualism', but also poses "a major threat to democracy and an impediment to the development of a fully functioning public sphere" (p. 59). Therefore, as Moore (2012) claims, the current global superdiversity should be examined from a critical perspective to scrutinize how dominant ideologies are constructed and create constraints for individuals and groups to participate in the public sphere. In other words, the current superdiversity is not just about a happy celebration of linguistic heterogeneity (Varis and Wang 2011); rather it should be understood as a contested *ideospace* in which language ideologies concerning both diversity and homogeneity are discursively constructed. The investigation of this complexity requires an analysis of "political and historical embedding" in language policing (Blommaert and Rampton 2011, p. 3). I will now discuss language policy and multilingualism in Nepal as the background of the study.

Language policy and multilingualism in Nepal

Nepal, a country in the Himalayas, is home to 123 languages and 126 ethnic/caste groups (Central Bureau of Statistics 2011). The 2011 Census shows that 44.6 percent of the total population speak Nepali, followed by Maithili (11.7 %), Bhojpuri (5.98 %), Tharu (5.77 %), Tamang (5.11 %), Newar (3.2 %), Bajjika (2.99 %), Magar (2.98 %), Doteli (2.97 %), and Urdu (2.61 %). The other languages, for example, include Rai, Limbu, Gurung, Tharu, Santhali, and Rajbanshi. Despite

this diversity, only Nepali is used in government offices, courts, schools, and other public spheres.

The one-language-one-nation ideology, which is built upon the 18th century discourse of European nationalism, has contributed immensely to the linguistic homogeneity in the country. Since the formation of modern Nepal (1768/9), the nation-state has adopted and vigorously implemented a "one-language-one-nation" policy; only Nepali has been recognized as the official and 'national' language, while the other minority languages were legally banned in schools, media, and government offices until 1990. As Anderson (1991) argues, nation-states adopt a monolingual policy to instill the assumption among their people that nationalism can only be enhanced when people speak a common, standard language. Nepal adopted a Nepali-only policy as a way to unify its diverse ethnic, cultural, and linguistic groups of people under one common national identity, Nepali. With this assumption, the nation-state has paid significant attention to Nepali language development while ignoring the importance of other languages. The state apparatuses—courts, schools, universities, government offices and other institutions—have been used as a means to support the reproduction of the Nepali-only ideology since the formation of modern Nepal. For example, the country's first educational plan, the Nepal Education Planning Commission (1956), banned the use of minority languages in school. The Commission states that "the study of a non-Nepali local tongue would mitigate against the effec-tive development of Nepali" (p. 97). It further asserts "[i]f the younger generation is taught to use Ne-pali as the basic language, then other languages will gradually disappear, and greater national strength and unity will result" (p. 97). With an aim to develop Nepali as the "true national lan-guage", the Commission claims that "local dialects and tongues, other than standard Nepali, should vanish from the school and play-ground as early as possible in the life of the child" (p. 96). This ideology was strengthened by subsequent education policies until 1990 (Phyak 2011, 2013; Weinberg 2013).

The public has a commonsense idea that obtaining education in the dominant language only (Nepali) is the best option. As critical political theorists (e.g., Althusser 1971; Gramsci 1971) argue, the reproduction of such an ideology can be taken as the dominant language hegemony in the multicultural, multilingual, and multiethnic situation of Nepal. By reproducing the monolingual ideology, language policies in education and other public spheres are ignoring the profound importance of indigenous languages, cultures, identities, and epistemologies. Scholars (e.g., Hornberger 2005; Skutnabb-Kangas and Heugh 2012) consistently argue that an equitable education provides a notable space for students' multilingual practices, through which they construct and invest in their identities.

Although the nation-state paved the way for the formation of ethnic organizations to promote indigenous cultures and languages (Eagle 1999; Sonntag 2007), the post-1990 democratic governments have still reproduced the Nepali-only ideology through various state mechanisms. The 1990 Constitution created a stratified order of indexicality (Blommaert 2010) in which Nepali is indexed as the *nation's language* while all other languages are defined as *national languages*. Such an unequal treatment of languages resulted in the displacement of indigenous languages from schools and other public spheres. Moreover, this dichotomy clearly shows that the

nation-state recognizes Nepali as the symbol of national identity, but it is not accountable for the promotion of other minority languages. For example, the Supreme Court (June 1 1999) banned the use of local languages in three local government offices—Kathmandu Metropolitan (Newari), Rajbiraj, and Dhanusha (Maithili). The court claimed that the use of languages other than Nepali goes against the constitutional spirit: Nepali-only as the national/official language. The indigenous people have called the court's verdict the *Linguistic Black Day* and protested against it by organizing various rallies and mass meetings throughout the country.

Rights-based discourses have emerged as a major agenda in post-2006 politics. The 2006 People's Movement, which overthrew a long history of the monarchy and paved the way for Nepal to become a Federal Democratic Republic, has opened up a greater space for indigenous communities, women, lower caste people (Dalits), religious minorities (Muslims), and Madhesis (people from the lowland region of Terai) to participate in critical discussions on policies concerning language, education, and culture. A tangible change is the use of indigenous minority languages, although to a very limited extent, in various public spheres. Gorkhapatra, the state-owned daily newspaper, has provided a two-page space for twenty-eight different languages. Radio Nepal currently broadcasts news bulletins in eighteen different languages. Most importantly, the indigenous communities are publishing their own newspapers, newsletters, magazines, and story books in their own languages. For example, Limbu and Rai Bantawa indigenous people are publishing Tanchopa and Bungwakha magazines, respectively.

The 2007 Interim Constitution has recognized the multicultural and multilingual identity of the nation-state and guarantees mother-tongue education as a fundamental right. The Ministry of Education (MOE) has recently developed a multilingual education policy (MLE) which provides indigenous languages with a space as the medium of instruction up to Grade 3. However, this policy has not been effectively implemented for various reasons. The increasing influence of neoliberal ideology in education, particularly the unregulated privatization of education, is the most powerful force in devaluing the relevance of the MLE policy (Phyak 2013; Phyak and Bui 2014). Following the nation-state's capitalist economic policy (Shakya 2009), the private sector is involved in establishing private schools, particularly in urban settings. These schools, which mainly serve the interests of middle- and high-class families, adopt a de facto English-as-medium-of-instruction policy. By following this policy, public schools throughout the country are now switching from Nepali to English as the medium of instruction. Moreover, the current educational policies, such as the 2009 School Sector Reform Plan (SSRP) and the 2007 National Curriculum Framework for School Education, consistently reproduce the rhetoric of globalization and the need for education policy that addresses the global standard. For example, the SSRP states that "globalization and a growing market economy have resulted in an increasing number of people who now regard literacy as one of the basic survival skills" (p. 29). The growing number of national and international non-governmental organizations, international educational programs such as A-levels, and students going abroad to study (e.g., in the USA, UK, and Australia) have also tremendously contributed to the valorization of English in the country.

The above discussion shows that both global and local sociopolitical and economic forces shape language policies in Nepal. While some forces impose hegemony, others challenge them. In what follows, I discuss how ideologies are constructed and challenged within a Facebook group.

The Facebook group and method of the study

The Facebook group in this study was created to discuss issues concerning federalism in Nepal in the context of the post-2006 political change. Although statistics show that only 2,690,162 (9.0 % of the total population by June 2012) and 1,940,820 (6.5 % of the total population by December 2012) Nepalese use the Internet and Facebook,[1] respectively, a larger number of Nepalese from various diasporas (e.g., the USA, UK, Australia, and the Gulf) participate virtually in the discourses related to the sociopolitical issues of Nepal. After the 2006 political change, various Facebook groups have been created for the purpose of political campaigns. For example, before the dissolution of the Constituent Assembly (CA) on May 27, 2012, Nepal Unites, a Facebook group, was able to gather thousands of Nepalese youth in front of the CA building in Kathmandu to remind the lawmakers and political leaders to deliver a long-awaited new constitution for the country.[2] However, the first CA was dissolved as the political parties could not forge a consensus on the nature of federalism; this dissolution has created heated debates about the state's future political path in social media.

Sanghiyatako Bishayama Khulla Bahas [Open Discussion on Federalism] is one of the most active Facebook groups in which members share ideas on federalism and other sociopolitical issues in Nepal. Although there are more than 8,400 (as at 09/01/2013) members in the group, all do not actively participate in the discussions. As a member since August 2012, I have been closely observing the language practices and discussion topics posted within this group. While I am equally interested in all discussion topics, I have paid significant attention to the topics that are closely related to language politics, identity, and ethnic issues. I have collected some sixty excerpts of discussions between August 2012 and May 2013.

I also had online Facebook chats (three each) with two active members—Baj and Rekh (pseudonyms) and one passive member—Min (pseudonym)—of the group. While Baj speaks Nepali as his first language, Rekh's first language is Magar, one of the indigenous minority languages in Nepal. Rekh can also speak Nepali and English. Baj most dominantly uses English (with very little Nepali) in Facebook discussions, but Rekh consistently uses Nepali. Min does not actively participate in Facebook discussions although he regularly reads other members' posts in the group. He had contributed only three posts by the end of May 2013. My online chats

[1] Data taken from Internet World Stats http://www.internetworldstats.com/stats3.htm.

[2] See http://www.voanews.com/content/nepals-youth-turn-to-social-media-in-constitution-campaign-122860749/140124.html).

with these members included the topics of language and politics in Nepal. Each chat was 10–30 minutes long.

The members of the Facebook group have various professional, political, ethnic, and regional backgrounds. Some members are national political leaders and student activists, while others are indigenous leaders; some are professors, school teachers, and businesspeople, while others are journalists, writers, and students. Due to a power-cut (for approximately 16 hours a day in winter), members who are living in Nepal cannot regularly participate in the discussions.

Although there is no explicit language policy for this Facebook group, most conversations are dominated by Nepali and English. The members use both Devanagari and Roman scripts to express their views in Nepali. In the reminder of this paper, I analyze how language ideologies are constructed and countered in language policing within this Facebook group.

One-nation-one-language ideology, nationalism, and globalization

The one-nation-one-language ideology invokes the assumption that nationalism can be best fostered if all citizens speak a common standard language (Anderson 1991; Milroy 2001). By legitimizing the power of the dominant language, spoken usually by the higher- and middle-class people, this ideology fails to recognize the importance of minority languages in education, mass media, and other state apparatuses. Critical language policy studies (e.g., Ricento 2006; Shohamy 2006; Tollefson 2013) consistently argue that nation-states impose the hegemony of one dominant language through various state mechanisms, such as schools, citizenship tests, and public signboards. These and other scholars (e.g., Lippi-Green 1997; Wiley and Wright 2004) claim that the one-nation-one-language ideology is closely associated with racial discrimination (e.g., Standard American English marginalizes the use of Black English in America), minority language and identity loss, and the exclusion of minority language speakers from the public sphere. This ideology is constantly reproduced in this Facebook group as well. For example, while actively participating in discussions on Nepal's language issues in the current changed political context, one member questions "matribhasha bolera ke huncha?" [What's the use of speaking a mother tongue?], and goes on to say that "nepali hamro rastriya pahichan ho" [Nepali is our national identity]. As Blommaert (1999) argues, this view reflects the historicity of the monolingual ideology that the nation-state has adopted; in Nepal's case, held for the last two and a half centuries under the guise of national unity.

However, this ideology is constantly challenged by members who represent various indigenous ethnic communities. For example, in responding to another member's post, which states that everyone must speak Nepali to show their *Nepali identity,* Rekh argues that "नेपालीमात्र नेपाली भाषा होइन" [Nepali only is not the Nepali language]. He further claims that "nepalma boline sabai bhasha nepali hun" [All languages spoken within Nepal are Nepali]. His view challenges the idea that there is an essential linkage between language and nationality, and reconstructs a counter-ideology that redefines Nepali nationalism as an assemblage of multiple

languages, rather than a single language, Nepali. However, there was a strong reaction against Rekh's ideology. In the following excerpt, LT and RR are discussing what languages they must use in Facebook. LT predominantly uses English in Facebook because she 'can't type Nepali' [in Devanagari script] in Facebook. However, RR, who had just started using Facebook on his cell phone, was trying to convince her that she must use Nepali because 'she is a Nepali'.

Excerpt 1: u r Nepali

1. LT: My problem, I can't type in Nepali in the facebook!!
2. RR: Don't say like that, u r nepali u should type on
3. nepali language not in english.
4. LT: As I said I tried to use Unicode to write in Nepali but couldn't make it and
5. I'm perfect in Nepali typing using Preeti[3] font brother which you might be able to
6. type it. You have to learn to understand others' problem, without imposing
7. your views!
8. RR: Sister, I can understand english also, but I want to chat with u on
9. nepali language Becoze u r nepali an me also nepali person
10. but my study is nothing then ur study that y I request
11. to u to write on nepali.

RR insists that LT should use Nepali because she is 'Nepali'. Although RR uses English, his view indicates that using languages other than Nepali does not display the iconic representation of Nepali national identity. For RR, the use of English in Facebook does not show one's *Nepaliness*. RR also argues that he wants to 'chat' with LT in Nepali. Most strikingly, he makes an iconic comparison of English as the language of 'educated people'. He argues that his 'study [educational qualification] is nothing', compared to LT's qualification so he wants LT to use Nepali on Facebook. At the same time, while reproducing the Nepali-only ideology, RR also challenges the standard language ideology through his own non-standard use of English. For example, 'type on', 'chat on', 'u r' 'ur' and 'that y' show that RR's English is more non-standard than LT's English. The monolingual ideology is also salient in the resistance discourses. While countering RR's Nepali-only ideology, LT argues that she must use English because she cannot type in 'Nepali Unicode', a Romanized version of Nepali, on Facebook. Most strikingly, although she does not like the way RR is 'imposing' his one-language-one-nation ideology, she is also reproducing the English-only monolingual ideology. She believes that it is 'meaningless' to use both minority languages and Nepali on Facebook. She further claims that because nobody on Facebook understands her own first language 'Tamang' (one of the indigenous languages in Nepal), she must use English to communicate with her Facebook friends. Not all members in the group actively participate in the discussions. As pointed out by a passive member, Min, in a Facebook chat, a major reason is the dominance of English in the group. He says that "ma angreji lekhna ramro sakdina" [I cannot write English well.]. He reveals that "jasle angreji ramro lekhcha uniharu matra badhi

[3] Preeti is one of the Nepali fonts.

chalfal garchan" [Only those who can write English better dominate the discussions.]. He further maintains that "fesbuk ma nepali taip garna alik garo huncha" [It is difficult to type Nepali on Facebook.]. This implies that English language dominance and technological difficulties have resulted in the exclusion of some group members from interacting on Facebook.

Hierarchies of language are also visible in the language policing of this Facebook group. In Excerpt 2 below, PT, another member of the group who dominantly uses English on Facebook, talks about the importance of English as a global language. As the discussion on language and nationalism becomes more intense, PT tries to convince other members like Rekh, who challenges the ideology of monolingual nationalism, by making an iconic comparison of English as the language of 'bhumandalikaran' [globalization].

Excerpt 2: bhumandilakaran [Globalization]

1. PT: के तपाइलाई थाहा छ? अहिलेको जटिल विश्वमा आफ्नो देश र भूमण्डलीकरणको
   ke tapalilai thaha cha? ahileko jatil biswama aafno desh ra bhumandalikaranko
2. भेलमा परेर अगाडी बढ्न र विश्व ग्यान, बिज्ञान र प्रबिधि बाट फाइदा लिदै राज्य
   bhelma parera agadi badhna ra biswa gyan, bigyan ra prabidhi bat phaida lidai rajya
3. संचालन कुनै यौटा साझा भाषा नबोली सुख छैन। अहिलेको जस्तो अंग्रेजी, चिनिया, हिन्दि
   sanchalan kunai euta sajha bhasha naboli sukh chaina. ahileko jasto angreji, chiniya, hindi
4. र युरोपियन भाषा हरुमा जुन रुप मा बढ्दो रुचि र आफ्नै भाषा मा चाहि घट्दो छ,
   ra yuropian bhashaharuma jun rupma baddo ruchi ra aphnai bhasha ma chahi ghatdo cha,
5. तेस्लाई हेर्दा 3 करोड नेपाली ले बोल्ने साझा भाषा नै खतरामा परेको देखिन्छ, अरु
   teslai herda 3 karor nepalile bolne sajha bhasha nai khatarama pareko dekhinhca, aru
6. ससाना समुह ले बोल्ने भाषा को झन् कुरै नगरौ।
   sasana samuhle bolne bhasha ko jhan kurai nagarau.

[Do you know? In this complex world, we are obliged to use a common language to run the nation-state's daily business; embrace the flow of globalization; and enjoy the benefits of global knowledge, science, and technology. Now, there is an increasing interest in [learning] English, Chinese, Hindi, and European languages, but people do not speak their own language. If we look at this trend, the common language spoken by 30 million Nepalese [Nepali] is endangered. Do not even talk about other small languages.]

While PT is valorizing English as the language of 'bigyan ra prabidhi' [science and technology] (line 2), he is also creating an *iconic boundary* between the people who use and who do not use English on Facebook. As Milani (2008) argues, such iconization of English in Facebook language policing constructs *a false assumption* that those who cannot use English are not able to know about science and technology. Most importantly, while showing his concerns about the *endangerment*

of Nepali, due to global English language spread, PT is trying to diminish the voices of the people who argue for the importance of 'minority languages' (lines 5–6). In this sense, the ideological construction of 'English as a global language' acts as a powerful force to *erase* minority language discourses in Facebook language policing. As Irvine and Gal (2000) contend, since minority language discourses do not fit into dominant language policy discourses, which are shaped by the ideologies of nationalism and globalization, Facebook language policing seems to reproduce the erasure of voices promoting minority languages. As McCarty (2003) argues, due to the increasing flow of globalization of which the flow of technology is a part, "the currency of 'world' languages is enormously inflated, while that of local languages is flattened and devalued" (p. 147). This further implies that Facebook language policing discursively reproduces the English-as-commodity ideology.

Economic capital and market-based language ideology

The symbolic dominance of English on Facebook is shaped by its economic capital in the global linguistic marketplace (Bourdieu 1991). In his post, Baj says "abako bhashik sanskritik ebam jatiya pahichan biswabyapi pratispardhale nirdharan gardach" [The global competition will determine current linguistic, cultural, and ethnic identities]. Countering the views that evoke the linguistic rights of minority languages, Baj further warns that everyone should be 'aware' of the fact that whether or not a particular language is used in the public sphere is not determined by the nation-state but by the global market. Another participant (TT), who predominantly uses English, claims in the following excerpt that she "just cares language which has a higher economic and symbolic value in the market."

Excerpt 3: Market

> I don't care about my language… I just care which language is spoken in the world most and which language has value in the market as per the time demand. I don't holler about any things because I don't own anything. …I prefer to write in an international language so that my all friends … can understand what I'm sharing and learning and they can also share their views with me.

TT says that she prefers to use an 'international language' to communicate with her friends from different countries. A transnational network that she developed through Facebook leads her to use English. TT's view "I-don't-care-about-my-language" suggests that ethnic minority languages are not used on Facebook because of their low economic capital. As further shown in the following excerpt, the group members also construct 'a new world order' in which the English language receives a greater privilege.

Excerpt 4: A new world order

> Globalization has created a new world order.…Developed countries govern the world with one government/politics, one economy, and one language.

The 'new world order' refers to the new linguistic order, created by globalization, in which English remains at the top (Aronin and Singleton 2008; Fishman 2000). The construction of a "one government/politics, one economy, and one language" ideology at the global scale is the fractal recursivity of the local construction of Nepali-only monolingual ideology, which dominates the Nepali public sphere. This recursiveness of the monolingual ideology, as Baj argues in the above excerpt, is shaped largely by the global market economy in which English is the most dominant language. Baj's view shows that the market-based justification of English language dominance has created a stratified order of languages in which indigenous and ethnic minority languages remain at the bottom. However, the group members from different indigenous ethnic groups constantly challenge such ideologies and continue to promote discourses concerning minority languages.

Mother tongue ideology and redefining nationalism

The indigenous minority language discourses in this Facebook group persistently reproduce an essentialist 'mother tongue' ideology which reconstructs the assumption that language and ethnicity have a fixed and one-to-one correspondence (Skutnabb-Kangas 1981; Weber and Horner 2012). While trying to redefine Nepal's identity as a 'multilingual, multicultural and multiethnic' country, indigenous people equate indigenous minority languages as 'mother tongue'. As seen in the following excerpt, indigenous ethnic minorities focus on their linguistic rights as a way to maintain linguistic diversity.

Excerpt 5: Respect all languages

1. BP: हरेक जात जाति समान हुन समान हक अधिकार हुनुपर्छ। सबै भाषा धर्म सस्कृतिको सम्मान गरिनुपर्दछ ।
   harek jat jati saman hun saman hak adhikar hunuparcha. Sabai bhasha dharma sanskritiko samman garinu parcha

   [Every ethnic/caste group should have equal rights. All languages, religions, and cultures should be respected.]

2. ASJ: nepali pahichan ahile boliraheko ra lekhiraheko bhasama matra hoina ni
3. yo ta hindi lipi jasto po chha ta..nepal ko aafnai bhasha ra lipi chha jun yo rajyale swikarnai parchha..

   [The script that we are using for the Nepali language does not show our Nepali identity. This looks like the Hindi script. Nepal has its own language and script that the state has to recognize.]

BP and ASJ argue that all languages and cultures should be treated equally so that the nation-state's linguistic diversity is maintained. By saying that 'all languages should be respected', BP is challenging discriminatory language policies against the minoritized languages. Both BP and ASJ strongly claim that the nation-state has to promote the use of minority languages to preserve its multilingual and multicultural identity. Like BP and ASJ, other members who speak minority languages as their first language, believe that 'their language' is essentially linked with their ethnic identity. For example, a Newari first-language speaker says "hamro matribhasha hamro pahichan ho" [Our mother tongue is our identity.]. ASJ further argues that the Devanagari script of Nepali does not show the Nepali national identity. While saying "nepal ko aafnai bhasha ra lipi chha" [Nepal has its own language and script.], he is referring to the Newari language (the language spoken by the Newar indigenous people). The United Nations has listed the Ranjana script of the Newari language as Nepal's official script, but Devanagari script is listed as the script for Hindi, an official language of India. Moreover, as seen in the following excerpt, ethnic minority people are redefining Nepali nationalism from a multilingual perspective.

Excerpt 6: Pahichan ra panhuch [identity and access]

1. GS: sarakari kaamamaa janajatile kani kani pani khas bhaasha bolnai parne.
2. tara ti khasharule bhane aru bhaashaa kanhi kahilyai siknai naparne. ho yahi bibhed rahekale aafno pahichan ra panhuch khoje.

[The ethnic minority people should speak the Khash language for official purposes. But the Khas people never have to learn other languages. Because of this discrimination, the ethnic minorities are reclaiming their identity and access.]

In the above excerpt, GS seeks to redefine Nepali nationalism as a plural and inclusive unit that portrays Nepal's multicultural and multilingual identity (Lal 2012; Lawoti and Hangen 2013). He redefines Nepali as the 'Khas' language, the native language of the Khas people (traditionally known as high caste Chhetri). History shows that the past Khas rulers renamed their native language, once called Khas, as 'Nepali', and imposed it as the symbol of national identity (Gellner et al. 1997). As PG (in the following excerpt) contends, the iconization of Nepali as the national language indexes the Khas language as the privileged language and erases the identities of other indigenous ethnic minority languages.

Excerpt 7: gahro parecha [difficult for you]

तिम्रै भाषा-लिपी पढ्नु त् तिमीलाई गाह्रो परेछ। तिमीले आदिवासी भाषाहरुमा पढ्नु परेको भए, के हुन्थ्यो?

timrai bhasha-lipi padhnu ta timilai gahro parecha. timile aadibashi bhashaharumaa padhnu pareko bhae ke hunthyo?

[If it is difficult for you to read your own language and script, how would you feel if you had to read in indigenous languages?]

In this Facebook group, the ideological contestation between dominant and minority language discourses engenders the fixed dichotomy between the 'we-code' and 'they-code' (Fuchsel and Rojo 2003). In the above excerpt, PG is referring to Nepali first-language speakers when he refers to it being "difficult for *you* to read in *your own* language and script." He further questions "How would *you* feel if *you* had to read in indigenous languages?" Here, PG is indicating that *only* indigenous ethnic minority people (we-code for PG) have experienced difficulties learning literacy in the dominant language, Nepali. Such dichotomous ideologies also recur through the iconization of indigenous minority people as *narrow-minded* and *traditional* simply because they talk about minority language revitalization, ethnic identity, and multilingualism. For example, one member in the group questions "yo jamana jatbhat ra bhashabhashi ka sana tina kura garera ke huncha?" [What is the meaning of talking about the trivial issues of ethnicity and languages in this age?]. But indigenous ethnic minority group members consider their language to be an important aspect of their historical and cultural identity. For example, PS, a journalist and an active member of the group, contends that the government has not paid attention to promote "matribhasha" [mother tongues] in education and media. For him, indigenous minority languages are 'mother tongues', which show their heritage ethnic identity.

Discussion and conclusion

This paper raises three important issues regarding language policing on Facebook. First, it indicates that Facebook language policing should be understood as an *ideospace* in which both centripetal and centrifugal forces co-exist (Bakhtin 1981). In this ideospace, multiple actors construct and contest ideologies about language, ethnicity, and nationalism. Although Facebook has allowed for the enactment of a certain level of fluid and mixed language practices (English and Nepali in this paper), the ideological construction of these languages through iconization, fractal recursivity, and erasure are still reproducing linguistic homogeneity and uniformity (Irvine and Gal 2000). Such ideological constructions in Facebook language policing are influenced by both global and local sociopolitical and historical forces (Androutsopoulos 2009). In other words, Facebook language policing is an intersection of the total 'linguistic culture' (Schiffman 1996), which includes actors' beliefs, ideologies, and cultural backgrounds. We also see that ideological contestation on Facebook reproduces current offline discourses in which Nepali and English are iconized as markers of national identity and globalization, respectively, while members of ethnic minorities are constantly challenging these ideologies.

Second, although Facebook language policing provides a space for both modernist and postmodernist language ideologies, I have attempted to show that the former is more salient than the latter in the ideospace of the Facebook group discussed in this paper. Both minority and dominant language discourses reproduce modernist language ideologies focusing on homogeneity and fixity. While resisting the historical hegemony of the Nepali-only policy, ethnic minority members reconstruct an ideology that invokes a primordial relationship between language and ethnicity. They consistently argue that their identity is expressed only when their 'mother tongues' are recognized in the dominant public sphere. This modernist ideology also recurs in discourses about dominant languages either in the guise of nationalism (Nepali) or globalization (English). As seen in this paper, the iconization of English as the language of 'science and technology' has reconstructed an ideology which seeks to erase discourses about minority languages. Most strikingly, this iconization serves as a hegemonic force to limit the voices of ethnic minority people who would wish to challenge monolingual ideologies.

This paper shows evidence of "modernist responses to postmodern conditions" (Blommaert et al. 2009, p. 204) in Facebook language policing. We see that Facebook language policing "may contain ideological and practical features that defy or reverse the very essence of … fragmentation, hybridization, destabilized identities" (Blommaert et al. 2009, p. 204). In this sense, knowing about the mobility and mixing of languages might not be sufficient to understand ideological complexities in the ideospace of Facebook language policing. Rather, it is necessary to unravel how this ideospace serves as an "arena where language policies through public debate can be informed, challenged, and transformed" (Lane 2009, p. 223). In this kind of debate, multiple publics representing different voices and ideologies emerge, as can be seen even within one Facebook group, as in this paper. While voices concerning Nepali monolingual nationalism and the market-based iconization of English represent the dominant public, voices that call for the redefinition of nationalism and the promotion of multilingualism exemplify language policy counterpublics (Warner 2002). Language policy counterpublics emerge as the dominant public erases alternative language ideologies and practices of ethnic minority people through various normative processes. For Warner (2002), the members of a counterpublic, however, should not be understood as "merely a subset of the public, but constituted through a conflictual relation to the dominant public" (p. 423). A counterpublic "maintains at some level, conscious or not, an awareness of subordinate status" to challenge modernist hegemonic ideologies (Warner 2002, pp. 423–424). This means that Facebook language policing, as discussed in this paper, is also a space for constructing counterpublics, which, as Asen (2000) argues, "illuminate the differential power relations among diverse publics" (p. 425).

To conclude, this paper calls for a public sphere approach to language policy (Davis 2014; Tollefson 2013) to understand how dominant language ideologies and policies may not embrace alternative language ideologies and practices. This approach critically scrutinizes whether or not language policy ensures the participation and engagement of counterpublics in language policing. This study shows that although Facebook language policing provides a critical and agentive space for ethnic minority people to share their ideologies about language and

nationalism, their voices are discursively diminished through iconization, recursivity, and erasure (Irvine and Gal 2000). Moreover, we can see Facebook language policing as a complex intersection of modernity and postmodernity, public and private, and global and local. It is an ideospace: a space for the ideologies of multiple publics.

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Prem Phyak is a PhD candidate in Second Language Studies at the University of Hawai'i at Manoa, USA. His research focuses on the intersection of language ideologies, language policies and multilingualism in Nepal, with a focus on engaged ethnography and social justice in education. His areas of interest include multilingual education, indigenous epistemology, and youth agency and activism for sociolinguistic justice.